

Breaking Ties

Sara Aboobacker is one of the finest radical authors from Karnataka. She has written novels and short stories in Kannada. She is an outstanding author who has succeeded in revealing the patriarchal and unjust rules obligatory on women in the religion of Islam. Her first novel Chandragiriya Teeradalli has been translated into several languages. It has been translated into English by Vanamala Vishwanatha as Breaking Ties. It focuses on the life of Nadira, a young Muslim woman attempting to assert independence first from her father, and later, from her husband. She has an autocratic father. Her mother believes that a woman should be submissive. Barely into her teens, Nadira was married off to Rashid. But her father separated her from her husband and planned to give her in marriage to Salim, a rich and elderly person. Through this novel, Sara Aboobacker has voiced feminine sensibility and oppression of women in patriarchal society.

Summary

Born in the Western Ghats, the Chandragiri flows westward to join the Arabian Sea. At one point in its course, the river changes direction to flow north-south for a couple of miles, then turns west again and finally mingles with the sea. To the east of this curve is Kiliyuru; to the west is Bagodu village. The river Chandragiri dominates the narrative in many ways. It not only sets the boundaries to the bigger world outside; it also reflects and sympathises with the moods of the characters.

Mahammad Khan lived in Kiliyuru. Mohammed Khan was tall and well-built, light brown in complexion. He was rude, short-tempered and obstinate. He had to have his way in everything. A dictator. So, his friends were few.

When Mahammad Khan married Fatima, she was barely eleven - no age to know what marriage was all about. But Mahammad Khan was already past twenty-eight.

He had never been one to work hard. He was always seen chatting with people either on the river bank or in the mosque, with no thought for time. He went on without a care, knowing well that Fatima would somehow manage and provide for the family.

In the midst of all torture and pain, Fatima was still grateful to her husband for one thing. He had not remarried and imposed a second wife on her, though she had not produced a son. She was grateful that he hadn't eyed other women after marriage. However cruel her husband was, Fatima was still depended on him for a sense of security. She would get very anxious if he came home late. Whatever he was, a household without a man was no household, according to Fatima.

Mahammad Khan had two daughters. His elder daughter, Nadira, lived with her husband. Rashid and Nadira were made for each other. They had a baby. Her husband's house was situated to the west of the river. Nadira rarely missed her

mother's house. She was supremely happy. Not once had she nagged her husband to buy her this or that; not once had she hurt her mother-in-law. She had been ready to give her life for the people of that little Kavalli house.

Mahammad Khan was busy looking for a match for their younger daughter, Jamila. Somehow, he had managed to make as much jewellery for her as they had for Nadira. And they were struggling now to put together some money for her dowry. However hard he tried, to collect three thousand rupees for Jamila's marriage, Mahammad Khan was unsuccessful. The groom was from a good family. He even owned a small shop and they could manage a living, rolling beedis right there in the shop. In Khan's mind, the groom's greatest asset was that he lived in Kiliyuru itself.

The next morning Mahammad Khan set out for Manipura. When he reached Rashid's shop, his son-in-law greeted him respectfully. Making sure that nobody was around, he told Rashid the purpose of his visit. Now Rashid understood everything. But Rashid told him that he couldn't give him so much money. Mahammad Khan had never thought that his son-in-law would defy him like this.

Mahammad Khan went straight to his daughter's house. He asked Amina to send his daughter and the baby with him. In the beginning, she hesitated to send her daughter-in-law without consulting with her son. Even Nadira was not keen on visiting her parents. Mahammad Khan told his daughter that her mother was always thinking of her. At last, Amina decided to send her daughter-in-law with her father. After reaching his home, Khan declared that he won't send his daughter to her husband's house. Now Nadira understood all that had happened.

For Nadira, it was an endless stretch of darkness, with no moon in sight. Her only hope was her husband. Sooner or later, he would come to take her home. Nadira waited and waited for her husband and her mother-in-law, counting every hour. To kill time, she would sit with her sister and learn how to roll beedis. When she too helped, their income increased a little. Mahammad Khan was pleased with that. What had begun as a pastime had now become life's necessity. Her disgust towards her father also grew in proportion.

In the meantime, Mahammad Khan had sold a part of their coconut grove, the sole support of their life, and raised the money needed for Jamila's dowry. Though they managed the dowry, they fell short of money for wedding expenses.

Jamila's wedding was over. One day Paru, the fish-seller from Kavalli visited Mahammad Khan's house and handed a letter to Nadira. It was from Rashid. He had suggested Nadira to come with Paru. But Nadira told Paru that she could not come with her without telling her father.

Another day Aminamma, Nadira's mother-in-law, came to Mahammad Khan's house and carried Nadira's baby when Nadira and her mother were out of sight.

One evening as Mahamad Khan sat near the Kadavu, Jabbar of the banana plantation came over and sat by his side. He suggested Mahammad Khan to take talaq from Rashid and to marry off Nadira with New House Selim. Selim was a rich person. He had a wife and a houseful of children! His eldest son was older than Nadira by a few years.

The next morning Mahammad Khan set off to Manipura. He met his son-in-law Rashid and demanded for talaq threatening him. Rashid pronounced talaq three times at a mosque in the presence of a maulvi. But when her father proposed her marriage with Selim, Nadira said that she would kill herself by jumping into the Chandragiri. Mahammad Khan was worried. Now he thought of remarrying Nadira with Rashid. He consulted the maulvi. The maulvi said that according to the Qua'ran when a husband utters talaq three times, the relationship between him and his wife stands dissolved. If they have to come together again, the wife should remarry and get a talaq from the second husband. She has to wait for three months. Once it is proved that she is not pregnant by him, then the first husband can marry her.

Mahammad Khan's state of health started to worsen. He arranged the marriage of Nadira with the sixty-year-old Sheik Ali, a coconut picker. On the marriage day the maulvi asked Nadira's consent for the marriage. It took her a while before she could say "Yes". The nikah was over. Fatimma came over to Nadira and draped a new saree around her. Nadira told her mother that she needed some air. Nadira came straight to the river bank. She continued along the bank and reached the mosque. She walked towards the pond in the mosque. She plunged into the lake.

Characters

Nadira

Nadira was the eldest daughter of Mahammad Khan. She had read the Qua'ran thoroughly and never missed the namaaz, praying five times a day. Right from the time she was ten, she had been fasting for all the thirty days.

Nadira was married to Rashid. Rashid and Nadira were made for each other. Nadira would not touch her dinner until Rashid returned, whatever the time. Nadira rarely missed her mother's house. She was supremely happy. Not once had she nagged her husband to buy her this or that; not once had she hurt her mother-in-law. She had been ready to give her life for the people of that little Kavalli house.

She had never crossed the Chandragiri on her own. Doing so without the company of a male member of the family was unthinkable.

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Nadira hoped that her husband he would come to take her home. But her husband did not come. But one day her mother-in-law came and carried her baby. Her father got talaaq from her husband forcefully. He proposed her marriage with Selim who had wife and children. Nadira did not give her consent and said that she would kill herself by jumping into the Chandragiri. Then her father decided to remarry her with Rashid. But she had to marry another man and seek talaaq from him before marrying the first husband. Her marriage was arranged with sixty-year-old Sheik Ali. But on the marriage day she killed herself by plunging into the lake in the mosque.

Rashid

Nadira's husband Rashid ran a small business in that town. His house was there miles away from town - in a tiny village called Kavalli. His humble house was in the middle of a half-acre farm full of coconut, banana and arecanut trees. His household ran smoothly out of the income from the shop and the trees.

When Rashid married Nadira, she was barely fourteen. He was twenty-five. He had given in to pressure from his mother and consented to marry. Mahammad Khan had married off his daughter with as much pomp as he could manage. He gave ten sovereigns of gold and two thousand rupees in dowry. He had celebrated the wedding in a manner much appreciated by the people of that town.

Rashid had not seen Nadira before the wedding; only his mother Amina had. What Amina had to say after she had seen the girl was etched in Rashid's mind. "Rashi, the girl is still young, but very pretty. Large eyes, a bowl-shaped face and a complexion like kedige. I was told she has read the Qua'ran thoroughly and never misses the namaaz, praying five times a day. Right from the time she was ten, she has been fasting for all the thirty days. She is an ideal bride." Though his mother had reassured him, he still worried that the girl was too young and half-heartedly consented to marry. He saw her for the first time only on the wedding night.

On Fridays, Rashid did not go to work. He would stay home wandering about in the garden. In the afternoon, Rashid would go to the mosque for namaaz. On Friday evenings, he would go to Manipura to watch a movie. Of late, on Fridays, Rashid had started to stay home, wandering around the home and the garden, chatting with Nadira; this gave him more joy than watching films since he was literate, he started to bring magazines home trying to teach Nadira how to read.

Mahammad Khan

Mahammad Khan lived in Kiliyuru. His only asset was a one-acre coconut grove on the banks of the river and a small mud hut in the middle of that grove. A couple of cows, three or four goats and their young, and some fowl - these were the movable assets of Muhammad Khan's wife Fatima.

Mohammed Khan was tall and well-built, light brown in complexion and beard in the style of a maulwi. He would not set foot outside without a cap on his head, a shawl over it under court he was of the view that there was nothing as good as a coat to cover up their poverty. Never mind if Fathima did not have a good sari; he had to have a coat. He was rude, short-tempered and obstinate. He had to have his way in everything. A dictator. So, his friends were few.

He had never been one to work hard. He was always seen chatting with people either on the river bank or in the mosque, with no thought for time. He went on without a care, knowing well that Fatima would somehow manage and provide for the family.

Mahammad Khan was one of those who believed in the masculine principle to the total negation of the feminine. In his eyes, a woman was a creature without a heart, without feelings. She had to implicitly obey her father, husband, and then her sons.

He tries to separate his daughter from her husband and also tries to marry her off with an old rich person for the sake of money.

Fatimma

When Mahammad Khan married Fatima, she was barely eleven - no age to know what marriage was all about. All she knew was that she would be dressed in silk and gold by other women who would then sing and clap their hands. She had seen that there would also be a man dressed as a bridegroom. Beyond this, she knew nothing. Before she knew it, her marriage with Khan had taken place. But Mahammad Khan was already past twenty-eight.

In the midst of all torture and pain, Fatima was still grateful to her husband for one thing. He had not remarried and imposed a second wife on her, though she had not produced a son. She was grateful that he hadn't eyed other women after marriage.

However cruel her husband was, Fatimma was still depended on him for a sense of security. She would get very anxious if he came home late. Whatever he was, a household without a man was no household, according to Fatimma.

Selim

New House Selim owned a big hotel in Bombay. He had just built his new house. He had a lot of property - the betelnut estate adjacent to the Chandragiri, several other fields and estates. Selim had recently bought up Mahammad Khan's farm too. His eldest son, now living in Bombay, was older than Nadira by a few years. He had invited the whole town for a grand meal a couple of

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years ago for the hair trimming ceremony of his eighth child. He had chopped up two huge goats for the feast.

Selim tried to attract Nadira. Several times, he sent Khan baskets filled with fruits and sweets from Bombay. He sent Khan gifts of mundu and shirt lengths. He even dyed his hair, wore freshly laundered clothes and a Jinnah cap and walked around the farm he had bought from Khan, while a servant followed him, carrying an umbrella.

CRITICAL ANALYSIS

Breaking Ties 'Chandragiri Theeradalli' is a prominent novel and also a feminist text by the Kannada writer Sarah Aboobacker, which was later translated into English with the title 'Breaking Ties'. The novel introduces the readers to the miserable lives of Muslim women in Coastal Karnataka and Kerala. The author was also from a Muslim community. She was the first girl in her community to pass the matriculation exam. Her writing style is very simple and direct and mainly centered on the terrible lives of Muslim women and how they are excluded from all the major and minor decisions in their life and not allowed to claim their freedom and equality in the social, political and religious system. This novel has made a huge impact on the Muslim patriarchal society questioning its social evils constructed against women depriving them of their freedom and opinions. It is the story of a voiceless girl and her damaged life caused by her patriarchal father and by the religious rules that restricts her to make decisions in her own life. This novel reveals to the world the sacrifice that a woman has to make to live in a Muslim society and her life as a puppet in the hands of a male-dominated society losing the real joy of life and living a life directed by the men in their lives. The novel is about a young girl named Nadira who married at the age of fourteen and her struggle to control her own life according to her wishes which were not possible under the rules of her violent father. The other main characters of the novel include Nadira's father Mahammad Khan, her mother Fatima and her husband Rashid. The novel can be analyzed as a subaltern text, as it projects many accounts of domination over Muslim women and they are defenseless. The story discusses marital rape, social issues and divorce and how women are denied the chance to decide the vital events of their life. This novel gives a gist of the problems faced by the Muslim women and reveals the subaltern circumstance of the illiterate women, oppression of the poor and the exploitation of their life by the Muslim patriarchy. This story depicts the suppression and discrimination of Muslim women imposed by the Muslim community and patriarchal society. The themes of hypocrisy and double standards are very much relevant in this novel.

Because of the unfair Muslim rules in the community, women have been restricted all kinds of freedom and no right to gain an education. They are supposed to wear burka outside of their house. The women are married at an early age when they don't know anything about marital relationships. In the novel *Fatima*, Nadira's mother is married to Khan at eleven years of age which shows that she is just a little girl. After the marriage, women are supposed to act according to the likes and dislikes of a man, whether she likes it or not. All such rules are a result of the male-dominated patriarchal society and these men make the laws in such a way that everything is convenient for them without thinking about the rights and freedom of women as men enjoy without any authority over them to control their actions. In Nadira's case, when she needs to remarry her husband Rashid, an unfair rule is imposed on the women of a Muslim community that she needs to marry another man just for a night and spends a night with that person and can get the Talaq or divorce the next morning and the woman needs to wait for three months to know whether she is pregnant. If pregnant she needs to live one year with him and then she can remarry her first husband. This is one of the inadequate religious rules concerning marriage and women have no voice in taking such decisions she is supposed to obey these rules without considering her mental or physical scenario and none of this applies to men. The men are given complete freedom to choose the decision of marriage or divorce and they can break the marriage by just uttering the word 'Talaq' three times, which seems to be an irrelevant method and he can give divorce without consenting anybody. The Muslim community blindly believes and follows all the rules in their religious system, but sometimes they also find it wrong and unnecessary but they can't raise their voices against the rules and authority. Women have been restricted to all kinds of freedom and denied the right to education because society pictures women as ideal wives who shouldn't leave the house, caring for husbands, children and the elderly, cooking food and doing all the household chores without complaining. From the novel, we can derive a conclusion that the societal and religious rules and the patriarchal domination exploited the life of young Nadira without involving her in the decisions of her life. The novel is about the tragic story of a fourteen-year girl Nadira, she is from a Muslim community and is uneducated, and she always obeys her father and does all the household chores without complaining and suddenly she was married to a man named Rashid. This new life was somehow started very happily and continued for a year and then the problem arises when Khan, her father approached Rashid and asked for some money for his second

daughter's marriage, but Rashid was unable to give the money. Furious by this incident Khan took Nadira and her baby to his house without enquiring about this to her and without Rashid's knowledge. Later when Rashid approached Khan to send his wife back to his house, Khan cunningly manipulated him to get talaq from him and lied about Nadira that she is not interested in living with him anymore. Later Nadira realized that her father is responsible for breaking her relationship with Rashid. Then somehow both Nadira and Rashid contacted through letters, but she found it difficult to read and write letters as she is illiterate. Later Rashid's mother came to her house and took their baby to Rashid's house and at last Khan decided to help her remarry Rashid. But when he consulted about this with the chief authority figure in their community there is some procedures to be followed before remarrying. So for that, she needs to get married to another man and spend a night with him and can get the talaq the next day, but needs to live with that person if she is pregnant and later can remarry the first husband. But Nadira is not happy with this rule and reluctantly she agreed to marry a person for one day and Khan with the help of his friend found such a person for one-day marriage. But Nadira feels very irritated and uncomfortable spending a night with a stranger. She wanted to avoid that situation, so she went outside to the riverside of Chandragiri river and after spending some time thinking about her husband and child, she can't spend the night with another man and jumped into the river, thus escaping from the harsh realities of life. The story highlights the making of the religious rules, regulations and customs that the patriarchal hegemony has used against women for its convenience. The novel questions the patriarchal order and demands reform and justice for women. Resistance to patriarchal ideology is implicating the question which points out absolute disregard for the woman as an equal partner in marriage or her feelings. Being silenced by the patriarchy that controls women's lives in the name of religion, the protagonist an uneducated Muslim girl is unable to write her story of misery and indignity. The author suggests in the second half of the book takes for a Muslim girl to go to school and gives a voice in the first, to the predicament of Muslim women within the unilateral practices and customs of marriage in Islam. The first and second parts as twin narratives constitute an internal critique of Muslim patriarchy. The novel brings out the elements of triple oppression of family, society and religion and this made her escape into freedom through death. Aboobacker seems to challenge this ignorance by positioning a strong female personality based on her personality strength rather than family and social expectations. She criticizes

men's religious and cultural tendencies towards male brotherhood. She challenges the domination of men by emphasizing her strong female character who negotiates with all possible identities to continue to stick to her beliefs and actions.

Critical Analysis :

In 1981, Aboobacker published her first article; an editorial on communal harmony in a local monthly Kannada-language magazine, Lankesh Patrike. Following this, she began writing stories and novels focusing on her own community, the Beary people, a Muslim community living in some regions of Karnataka and Kerala. Sara

Aboobacker was born on June 30, 1936, to Pudiyapuri Ahmad and Zainabi Ahmad in Kasargod, Kerala. She is the best example of a radical author in Indian English-language writing. She fearlessly writes about cultural riddles in religions such as Islam, which are not permitted by the Muslim community. Neither religion nor community. The author uses fiction to communicate a message about religion's quirkiness and resistance against its dominance over human existence. Sara Aboobacker's work, *Breaking Ties*, champions feminine sensitivity, oppression, and subjugation under patriarchal control.

“What did you say? Those who call to buy them for marriage take

This speech again. I will not wear you”

– roared Khan (page: 33)

The above line shows the Khan's angeriness and his domination and oppression of women. The book's second section includes an autobiographical section that adds to the protagonist's motivation and relates to her life. The fiction, translated from the Kannada original, *Chandragiri Theeradalli*, explores the economic, gender, and religious relationships that shape domesticity in a patriarchal society. Women are often voiceless victims of male ideology and interpretations of religious texts. Hegemony is held by patriarchs. The translator retains the text's originality by keeping local customs, culture, and language while creating a sense of Indian domesticity. The translation challenges patriarchal discourse by using culturally relevant words.

The novel *The Breaking Ties* is named as a fictitious tale, which means Fictitious implies is made up or fictional. No matter how genuine Scarlett O'Hara appears in "Gone With the Wind," she is a fictional character created by

novelist Margaret Mitchell. The fictitious story follows the unfortunate predicament of Nadira, a young Muslim girl who is both mature and attractive. Despite being illiterate, she has a strong sense of self-worth and values her family, including her parents, husband, and in-laws. She inherited nothing from her father, who was pompous and domineering. At the age of fourteen, she marries a young man named Rashid. Mohammad Khan, the protagonist's father, becomes a villain and disrupts their idyllic lives. The father's vanity and greed for his daughter's beauty persists even after she has married and had a son. Furthermore, he considers his goal to be affluent. Only Nadira allows them a luxurious lifestyle. He takes his daughter and son to his house under the guise of visiting a nearby community.

To achieve his goal, the conspirator Mohammad Khan prevents Nadira from visiting her husband Rashid and arranges situations that force her to seek divorce. They are also separated against her consent, allowing him to collect wealth. Prior to their divorce. The brutality with which Muhammad Khan treated his child on the first night is heartbreaking. Nadira's situation exemplifies the psychological suffering caused by a struggle that prioritize the female body.

"Okay, Rashid, you got your child back right..... so give Talak to my daughter."

Kahan (page no: 52)

Muhammad Khan, father of Nadira, who destroys Nadira's marriage and wants her to marry a wealthy elderly spouse, the second time, represents the confident ideology that devalues women. The term confident ideology is as beneficial to women in that it encourages their husbands to provide for and protect them from their children.

The novel *Breaking Ties* was translated into English by a translator named Vananala Viswanatha, who gives a pretty comprehensive introduction to the novel's location. The author uses current translation techniques to describe the Muslim woman's environment, highlighting how translation may be used to express subaltern awareness. The translator explains in the introduction that the title was changed to *Breaking Ties*, which might have been translated into English as "On the Banks of Chandragiri".

The tale suggests reinterpreting religious norms employed by patriarchal power to oppress women. The novel challenges the patriarchal system and advocates

for reform and fairness for women. The question itself implies her emotions. The authors, translators, and editors of these works are all female and share a commitment to equality. Patriarchy is prevalent in books, and women experience different forms of oppression according to their caste, class, area, and other circumstances.

CONCLUSION:

The novel *The Breaking Ties* focuses on the development of religious norms, laws, and rituals that patriarchal hegemony has utilized against women for its own benefit. Aboobacker appears to combat this ignorance by emphasize a strong female individuality above familial and social norms. She criticizes men's religious and cultural attitudes towards male solidarity. She fights male dominance by emphasizing her strong female character, who negotiates with all potential identities in order to remain true to her views and deeds.

Patriarchy, as historically described, is a system of social interaction characterized by gender inequality between socially constituted men and women. This system of unequal social ties is interwoven in a society's political, social, cultural, and economic institutions, as well as in private home relations. In these systems of gender inequality, women are disadvantaged in a variety of ways in social relationships and organization. Women are collectively barred from political, social, and economic positions of power in patriarchal countries; women are underpaid for equal value labor; and women are more likely to face poverty and uneven access to resources, products, and services. While individual women may achieve success in a variety of areas, women as a separate social group.

The story criticizes the patriarchal society and calls for reform and fairness for women. Resistance to patriarchal ideology is inherent in the question, which demonstrates complete contempt for the woman as an equal partner in marriage or her feelings. The heroine, an ignorant Muslim girl, is unable to tell her narrative of sorrow and indignity because the patriarchy that governs women's life in the guise of religion silences her. The author discusses in the second part of the book what it takes for a Muslim girl to go to school and gives voice to the problem of Muslim women within.